

Sodium

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One of the most widespread elements on Earth, sodium is highly reactive and is always found combined with other elements. It is essential for life, and sodium chloride (table salt) is the most common sodium compound. Sodium compounds are found in everything from baking powder to fireworks, and salt is also used to de-ice slippery roads.



Pure sodium in an airless vial

Baking powder

Sodium hydrocarbonate—better known as baking soda—is added to cake batter in baking. During cooking, the baking soda releases carbon dioxide gas, which helps the batter rise, giving the cake a light, airy texture.



Transparent, cube-shaped crystal

Halite

The mineral halite contains sodium chloride. More commonly known as rock salt, this compound is vital for human and animal health. Halite is found as cubic crystals and forms as deposits around seas and lakes in dry climates when the saltwater evaporates.

Dead bodies were dried using natron.



Preserved forever

Uses for sodium go all the way back to ancient Egypt. The Egyptians believed in an afterlife, and they preserved the dead in a process called mummification. They used a mineral called natron—a mixture of different sodium compounds—to absorb the water in the body to dry it out before wrapping it in linen.



Heap of sea salt in a salt farm

Harvesting salt

Salt forms in some rocks, and, over time, it dissolves and runs into seawater. In shallow pools, wind and the sun evaporate the water, leaving thick heaps of salt that can be collected by farmers.